Such an assessment is not a retrospective view. Even in 1953, Mookerjee conveyed to PM Nehru that his handling of the Kashmir problem had neither enhanced our international prestige nor won us wide international support and sympathy. On the contrary, he felt that it had created ‘complications’ at home as well as abroad. He, therefore, urged Nehru to re-examine policy dispassionately rather than be carried away by ‘false internationalism’. This reference to complications abroad must be noted because that is precisely what came to preoccupy Indian diplomacy for the period thereafter. As Mookerjee was to state in Parliament, India went to the Security Council on the question of aggression, not on the question of accession. How this was distorted by interested powers is a parallel that he draws in a manner similar to Patel’s caution.

With the passage of time, the diplomatic consequences of the early misjudgements on Jammu & Kashmir have receded from public memory. It is possible that the gen-next is even unaware of the pressures that our country faced. Yet, this must be recalled in order to fully appreciate the significance of what was done in respect of Article 370 in 2019. The global manipulation of the Jammu & Kashmir situation is worth examining in some detail. This would explain what Mookerjee meant when he spoke of complications.

In December 1947, India referred the matter to the UN under Article 35 of the UN Charter as a threat to international peace and security created by Pakistan’s support to the invaders. There is a separate debate on whether this was the best pathway that India could have chosen at that time. But there is no need to get into that discussion. What we should bear in mind is that the British-appointed Governor General had, two months earlier, accepted the Instrument of Accession in regard to Jammu & Kashmir under the relevant legal provisions. But this did not stop major world powers from taking advantage of an opening that the situation provided.

As the recent colonial power, the UK was in the lead. It was also the one with the strongest post-Partition agenda and, therefore, the most mischievous. The UK influenced the passing of a Security Council resolution calling on both India and Pakistan to refrain from any acts that would aggravate the situation. In effect, the aggressor and the victim were put on par. Declassified records indicate that there was a clear strategy in the Commonwealth Relations Office to bring in Pakistani troops and balance out India.